What is anosmia?

Anosmia is the complete inability to correctly identify odors. It can arise from certain genetics, such as the presence of polymorphisms (rare DNA sequence variations) in the OR7D4 gene, an olfactory receptor responsible for detecting steroid-based odors, such as androstenone.

Olfactory testing is not a staple of general health screening, and as such, diagnoses of a disorder like anosmia depend on self-reporting, which, in turn, depends on the individual in question's ability to correctly identify their specific situation and their standard of "normal". In most cases, the consensus appears to be that self-reporting individuals have clarity on what is "normal" for them, but they often have difficulty identifying what exactly is causing the issue.

Anosmia as an isolated/idiopathic condition is quite rare, affecting around 3% of Americans over the age of 40, and only a minority of that demographic will go on to develop Parkinson's disease. This is because any disruption to olfactory functioning can be attributed to a wide variety of factors, from viral infections to aging.